

# Does **/init** make your AI coding agent better?

What the controlled studies say about **CLAUDE.md**, **AGENTS.md** and similar context files.

## SHORT ANSWER

# Not reliably.

- No controlled study found a frontier agent **reliably solving more tasks** with one.
- In the ETH Zürich study it made each task **20–23% more** expensive.
- The **rules** in the file get followed. The **codebase tour** does not help.

## FINDING 1

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# Your CLAUDE.md is really two different files.

### RULES → FOLLOWED

Name a tool in the file and the agent uses it **1.6× per task**. Leave it out: **under 0.01×**.

### CODEBASE TOUR → NO HELP

Overviews did not help agents find the right file any faster. A summary of code answers **4 of 45** questions about what it does. The code itself answers **27**.

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Better writing won't fix it: a frontier model's summaries scored **as poorly as a small 3B model's**.

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# Random rules scored as well as expert ones.

# 50 → 64%

of borderline tasks solved by Claude Code (Opus 4.6) — with **curated rules** and with **random rules** alike.

## THE FINE PRINT

58 of 500 tasks, one run each, no single result significant. Over the full benchmark: about **+1.6 points**. Having *a* file may nudge the agent. **What it says didn't matter.**

And **~9% of results flip** between two identical runs. Most published numbers can't tell a gain from luck.

# What measurably helped: writing down the agent's mistakes.

# 25.5 → 33%

of tasks solved, after the guidance file was **tuned against the agent's own failures**. Four repeated trials,  $p < 0.001$ .

## THE FINE PRINT

It helped the agent **find the right file**, not write better fixes. And it was an **open 35B model**, not Claude or Codex — nobody has tried it on a frontier agent yet.

# Run it. Then delete most of it.

- 1 Run `/init` once, as a draft.
- 2 Delete the architecture tour.
- 3 Keep only what the repo **can't tell the agent**: commands, gotchas, "do not" rules.
- 4 Each time the agent repeats a mistake, **add one line**.
- 5 **Prune**. A stale line is worse than none: agents follow the file over the code.

Full review, all sources and the verification log:

**[github.com/marcelpetrick/codingWithGPT/tree/master/claudeCodeInit](https://github.com/marcelpetrick/codingWithGPT/tree/master/claudeCodeInit)**